

Figure 2: Search and add software repositories

making the job a tad easier. For example, to include most of KDE 4.3 applications at one go, I first removed the `kde4` pattern that came from my base template, and added the one called 'KDE 4.3 Default Desktop'. Dependencies are all resolved and taken care of in the backend. When a package addition conflicts with another, it shows you the possible options to make amends.

The **Selected software** section is divided in two—patterns and packages. Note that the packages section will list all the packages that you've chosen (or automatically added when you included a pattern) but won't list the dependencies. This helps in keeping an eye on all the major packages that you select—and if required you can remove a package with a single click. The Web interface is based on the Ruby on Rails and Ajax technologies and that makes the service pretty interactive (a la Facebook, Gmail, etc).

Another of my requirements was to build an ISO image and keep the size within 700 MB so that I could pack it in a CD. Upon selecting a package, the left-hand pane of the Web page live-updates the download size, number of packages and patterns, besides there being an **Undo** button (or **Redo** when you delete a package) to keep things under check. It also shows you a warning if the size of the overall image becomes more than 700 MB. This is important because the 'Download size' info box on the left-hand pane is that of the individual packages that have been selected. A live ISO will have certain other things that take up more space. What I figured was that I needed to stop adding packages the moment the download size reached 630 MB, because the process of ISO creation adds another 70 odd MB to the overall size.

Once you're satisfied with the package selection, you can proceed for some finer-grained control over other settings, in order to personalise the appliance or distribution.

Get set

It's now time to access the **Configuration** section,

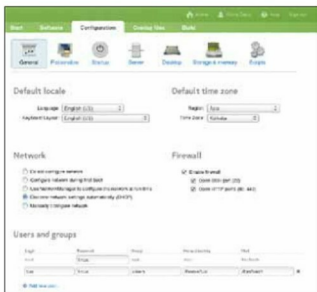


Figure 3: Configuring the general configuration options of our appliance

which is further divided into seven sections.

Under **General** (Figure 3), you'll need to set your language, keyboard layout, region and time zone choices. Next up, you can configure your network settings between an unconfigured network, configure on first boot, use NetworkManager, DHCP, and manual configuration. Leave the firewall **off** or **on** (with options to open default SSH and HTTP/HTTPS ports). And, finally, set the root password and add new users. By default, there's a user account called `tux` and its password (and that of the root's, too) is `linux`. You're free to change all these here.

In the **Personalise** section, you'll be able to set a logo and background for your appliance. There are a few images available by default with the option to add new logos and wallpapers. A nice touch by the Studio team is a live preview for Grub, the boot screen, the console and login screen option to give you an idea how they would look with your selection of graphics. I added a KDE logo to give it a more KDE feel and chose one of the wallpapers provided by SUSE.

Under the **Startup** tab you get to select the default run level (I wanted 5 for the graphical mode) and there's the option to add EULA (even multiple ones). The **Server** tab doesn't have much besides configuring the MySQL database, while the **Desktop** tab lets you set the user to auto-login and add start-up programs for users. The **Storage and Memory** section lets you set the RAM and disk size if you're creating a VMware or disk image. And, finally, the **Scripts** tab lets you add a custom script (if you wish to) at the end of the appliance build or when you finally boot it.

The next major section is called **Overlay files**. This one gives you a way to "...optionally add custom files to your appliance. Files added here will be copied into the appliance after packages are